

BETA-READING REPORT

Book: *The Last Love Letter*

Author: Amelia Rowan

Genre: Contemporary Romance

Manuscript Stage: First Complete Draft

Overall Impression

The manuscript has a strong emotional premise. The combination of unresolved love, grief, a mysterious letter, and the abandoned train station gives the story an immediate emotional and narrative hook.

The strongest element is Mara's relationship with Elias. Even before the reader knows the full history between them, the manuscript creates the feeling that their relationship carries unfinished emotional weight.

What Works Well

1. Emotional Hook

The opening immediately establishes Mara's grief and connection to her grandmother.

The discovery of Elias's handwriting is particularly effective because it turns an ordinary family mystery into a deeply personal one.

2. Atmosphere

The grandmother's house works well as a setting.

Details such as the old clock, photographs, furniture, and childhood memories make the house feel connected to Mara's past.

3. Mystery

The letter creates several useful questions:

- Why did Elias leave the letter?
- Why did Mara's grandmother have it?
- Why does the letter ask Mara to return to the train station?
- What really happened between Mara and Elias?
- Why does the ticket say "Home"?

These questions encourage the reader to continue.

Areas to Strengthen

Character Motivation

Mara's grief is clear, but the manuscript could explore her emotional history with Elias more gradually.

A few carefully placed memories throughout the early chapters would help the reader understand what was lost.

Romance Development

Because this is a romance, the relationship should not depend only on the mystery surrounding Elias.

The manuscript should show:

- Their friendship
- Their first attraction
- Their disagreements
- What made them compatible
- What eventually separated them

This will make the emotional payoff much stronger.

Pacing

The opening is effective, but the mystery should not answer itself too quickly.

I recommend allowing several chapters for Mara to uncover the truth.

Reader Questions

I would especially want the manuscript to answer:

Why did Elias leave?

What did Mara misunderstand about their relationship?

Why did her grandmother keep the letter?

Who knew about the letter before Mara discovered it?

Recommendation

Strong continue.

The story has a compelling emotional foundation and enough mystery to carry a full-length romance. The next revision should focus primarily on deepening Mara and Elias's relationship through memories and present-day discoveries.

Beta-reader rating: 8.5/10